



JUNE – PEAK SEASON MANAGEMENT

June is one of the busiest months in the beekeeping year. Colonies are often approaching their maximum population, nectar flows can be strong, and honey production may be well underway.

Although swarm season is beginning to ease in some areas, it should never be assumed that the risk has passed. Strong colonies can still swarm during June, particularly if inspections become irregular or hive space becomes restricted.

The focus during June is maintaining control. Colonies need space, regular inspections, health monitoring and good record keeping. Decisions made now will influence honey production and colony condition for the remainder of the season.

WEATHER, TEMPERATURE & SEASONAL TIMING (JUNE IN THE UK)

June generally brings longer days, warmer temperatures and increased forage availability across much of the UK.

Good weather often produces strong nectar flows, allowing colonies to gather significant quantities of nectar and pollen. However, periods of poor weather can still interrupt foraging activity and temporarily reduce incoming resources.

Large colonies require substantial food and space. Brood nests are often extensive, populations are high and the demand for storage space increases rapidly during strong nectar flows.

Inspections are usually easier to carry out than earlier in the season, but colonies should still only be opened during suitable weather conditions.

REALITY CHECK: Just because a colony has not swarmed in May does not mean it won't swarm in June



WHAT YOUR BEES ARE DOING

By June, many colonies are operating at peak strength.

Large numbers of worker bees are collecting nectar, pollen, water and propolis while the queen continues laying heavily. Drone populations are usually at their highest and brood nests can occupy a significant proportion of the hive.

The colony is attempting to:

- Raise brood
- Gather surplus honey
- Maintain colony temperature
- Reproduce through swarming

This combination creates pressure within the hive and requires careful management.

WHAT YOU SHOULD BE DOING IN JUNE

June is all about staying ahead of the bees.

Regular inspections should continue, swarm control measures must remain in place and hive space should be monitored closely.

You should ensure:

- Adequate super space is available
- Queen cells are checked regularly
- Colony health is monitored
- Records are kept up to date
- Equipment is available before it is needed

Strong colonies can develop very quickly during June and delays often create unnecessary problems.

REALITY CHECK : Running out of super space during a strong nectar flow is one of the quickest ways to increase congestion



INSPECTIONS – STAYING IN CONTROL

Many beekeepers continue inspecting colonies every seven days throughout June where swarm pressure remains present.

The purpose of inspections should be to:

- Confirm the colony is queenright
- Assess brood quality
- Check for queen cells
- Monitor colony strength
- Identify disease symptoms
- Assess available space

Inspections should remain efficient and focused. Unnecessary disturbance serves little purpose and can disrupt colony activity.

SWARM CONTROL – NOT OVER YET

Swarming remains possible throughout June.

While some colonies may have already swarmed earlier in the season, others may still be preparing to do so.

Particular attention should be paid to:

- Queen cells
- Congested brood nests
- Strong colonies
- Older queens

Any chosen swarm control method should be implemented confidently and consistently.

PRACTICE RULE: Continue checking for queen cells until swarm pressure has genuinely passed



HONEY FLOW & SUPER MANAGEMENT

June is often associated with some of the strongest nectar flows of the year.

Supers can fill quickly and colonies should never be left without sufficient storage space.

Supers should be added according to colony activity rather than a fixed calendar date.

Monitor:

- Nectar intake
- Super occupancy
- Drawn comb availability
- Honey stores
- Potential extraction timing

In some areas, early crops may be ready for harvesting during June.

COMB REPLACEMENT & FRAME MANAGEMENT

June provides excellent conditions for ongoing comb replacement programmes.

Older, dark or damaged brood comb can be removed gradually and replaced with new comb as colonies continue to expand.

Strong colonies are usually capable of drawing foundation readily during favourable conditions.

REALITY CHECK: If bees are actively working most frames within a super, another super may soon be required



HEALTH, DISEASE & VARROA MONITORING

June is an important observation period for colony health.

Look for:

- Patchy brood patterns
- Sunken cappings
- Discoloured larvae
- Unusual smells
- Deformed wings
- Weakening colonies

Any unusual findings should be monitored carefully and investigated further where necessary.

Varroa monitoring should also continue throughout the month.

Even where treatment is not planned immediately, information gathered now helps inform decisions later in the season.

FOOD & STORES

Food shortages are less common during June than earlier in the year, but they can still occur.

Poor weather, interrupted nectar flows or recently established colonies can all experience shortages.

Hive weight and food reserves should continue to be assessed as part of normal inspections.

PRACTICAL RULE: A strong colony can consume significant stores surprisingly quickly when supporting a large brood nest



EQUIPMENT & APIARY MANAGEMENT

June is not the time to discover that equipment is unavailable.

Ensure spare:

- Supers
- Brood boxes
- Frames
- Foundation
- Feeders
- Swarm control equipment

are available before they are required.

Apiary maintenance should also continue, including vegetation control, safe access routes and reliable water sources.

RECORD KEEPING

Accurate records become increasingly valuable during June.

Inspection records should include:

- Queen status
- Brood condition
- Swarm cells
- Super additions
- Honey production
- Disease observations
- Comb replacement

Good records support better decisions later in the season.



BeezKnees – June Apiary Master Guide

June apiary master guide for cool, temperate UK climate

<https://beezknees.co.uk/>

JUNE TAKEAWAY

June is about managing strong, productive colonies while maintaining control.

Honey production may be increasing rapidly, but swarm prevention, health monitoring and space management remain equally important.

Successful June management is achieved through regular inspections, adequate hive space, healthy colonies and accurate record keeping.

REALITY CHECK: The colonies you manage well in June are often the colonies that perform best for the remainder of the beekeeping season